

Matters of momentum

When we think of technology innovations, the few examples that come to mind instantly are those that have solved a longstanding problem. The car for example solved the problem of rapid personal transport, the laptop allowed us all to compute on the go, and the internet (apart from making us worship cats) forever changed how we live.

Even at a product level there were innovations that made things incrementally better. Apple didn't invent the touchscreen smartphone or the portable music player, but what it did was make those devices genuinely practical by solving many of the little problems that had plagued previous attempts – battery life, storage space, touch response, etc. There are many more examples like this, but space is a constraint here.

Technology, I believe, should solve a problem, fulfill a burning need, or make a user's life infinitely simpler. When designing a new product these principles should ideally be common sense. Thus, to make something that doesn't fulfil any of those elementary principles is a recipe for disaster, right? Surprisingly, the answer is both yes and no.

I was at an NVIDIA conference in Canada recently, where they announced a solution to graphical tearing and stutter – problems that have bothered us gamers since the dawn of computer graphics. This new technology got me making a mental list of all the other innovations in recent years that were built from the ground up to solve such problems. Turns out there aren't as many as we'd like to believe, and most were created simply because they could be.

Take Windows 8, for example; what real problems did we have with Windows 7 that it fixed? What need did the Surface RT meet? Honestly it seems to me like someone at Redmond just wanted to do something in the tablet space and decided to bootstrap Windows with a touchscreen to try and get in on the tablets action.

I'm not on a Microsoft witch hunt here. Even NVIDIA, whom I just applauded for one elegant solution, has something that just doesn't make sense. Look at SHIELD; why would you ever want to stream a PC game that's running in all its glory on a PC monitor to a portable small screen with a controller? It never made sense to me from the word go. Technology companies seem to be obsessed with being creative and innovating for the sake of innovation – building solutions for

problems that don't exist. Recently, they added a use case scenario that made a little more sense – stream your PC game to your large TV in another room using SHIELD.

Another example of possible success despite a lack of need: Steam OS. I had a chance to meet John Carmack in Canada and he said that when Valve approached him years ago asking for DOOM to be locked for distribution to Steam he thought they were crazy. "But look at Steam now!" he quickly added to those present. Even with Steam OS, he sounded skeptical about everything shifting ground up to a new platform (Linux), but as he said, "It's Valve. Years later we can look back at them as being prophetic, and it's purely because it's Valve I won't call them crazy this time." The sheer momentum that Steam has gathered as a platform might just be enough to propel Steam OS into success.

This momentum is the aberration to the rule of technologies and products that make sense. Take the iPad for example. When Apple launched it, it literally birthed an entirely new industry, despite the need for a "tablet" not being the strongest at the time. Even today, there are billions living their lives just fine without one, but if you happen to get one, all of a sudden you cannot imagine ever being without it. The Apple juggernaut made sure devs were churning out apps for it from Day 1. Can we really have an Apple product that flops anymore?

Most companies are hoping that the smart-watch will become what smartphones and tablets are today. I have serious doubts, because again this seems like a desperate attempt at innovation for the sake of it, and not really filling a need.

We don't need these incremental innovations, or duct-taped solutions. What we need are built from the ground-up new technologies – a newer and better interface than touch, radically new and efficient sources of portable power; we need today's equivalent of the car, the internet, the wheel and sliced bread, and the company that does it first will see all the world's momentum go with it – and our money too! 



Siddharth Parwatay
Features Editor

siddharth.parwatay@thinkdigit.com

"Technology companies seem to be obsessed with being creative and innovating for the sake of innovation – building solutions for problems that don't exist."



Got feedback about this column?
Drop me a line at:
siddharth.parwatay@thinkdigit.com